

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1996-05-13

To an individual believer

1 dear b ahá'í f riend,

2 your thoughtful letter. . . .

3 The questions raised in your letter go to the heart of the issues facing

4 bahá'ís everywhere at this critical point in world history. we are witnessing

5 the disintegration of the great civilization which has, for over two centu-ries, dominated world history and shaped the behavior and attitudes of the most influential sectors of modern society. The defining characteristic of this civilization has been a materialistic view of reality, the conviction that

6 both human consciousness and human society are essentially the products

7 of material forces and that it is to these forces that we must look for the resolution of the great problems facing our world.

8 clearly, this world view reflects a profound error about the nature of

9 humankind. it has demonstrated conclusively its impotence to solve any

10 significant problem facing the world's people today—political, social, eco-nomic, or moral. in the face of so massive a failure, a growing majority of

11 people everywhere are being forced to reexamine fundamental assumptions. Speaking some fifty years ago of this accelerating breakdown, the guardian

12 of the b ahá'í f aith wrote:

13 A tempest, unprecedented in its violence, unpredictable in its course, catastrophic in its immediate effects, unimaginably glorious in its

14 ultimate consequences, is at present sweeping the face of the earth.

15 . . . bewildered, agonized and helpless, [humanity] watches this great

16 and mighty wind of god invading the remotest and fairest regions of 226.4

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228 1996–2000 • The four Year Plan

229 55the earth, rocking its foundations, deranging its equilibrium, sunder-
230 ing its nations, disrupting the homes of its peoples, wasting its cit-
231 ies, driving into exile its kings, pulling down its bulwarks, uprooting
232 its institutions, dimming its light, and harrowing up the souls of its

inhabitants.227-1

233 As you have said, political calculations and partisan agendas that are
234 based on the interpretation of reality that our world has inherited from the past hold
no answers, whether socialist or capitalist, whether of the east or
235 the west.

236 The question arises, therefore, on what basis can the advancement of civ-
237 ilization and the development of human nature continue? it is bahá'u'lláh's
238 answer to this question that poses the fundamental challenge of our age. in asserting
that "this is the day in which god's most excellent favors have

been poured out upon men"

239 227-2 and that "the world's equilibrium hath been
240 upset through the vibrating influence of the most great, this new world or-
241 der,"227-3 bahá'u'lláh points humanity to the fulfillment of the promise that
242 has sustained our race throughout the past thousands of years of civilization.
243 his words envision an entirely new relationship between the regeneration of
244 the individual's spiritual life and the reconstruction of society. Again, to cite
245 the words of the guardian:

The revelation of bahá'u'lláh, whose supreme mission is none other

246 but the achievement of this organic and spiritual unity of the whole body of nations,
should, if we be faithful to its implications, be re-garded as signalizing through its advent the
comiNg of A ge of

The eNTire humAN rAce. it should be viewed not merely as

247 yet another spiritual revival in the ever-changing fortunes of man-kind, not only as a
further stage in a chain of progressive revelations,
248 nor even as the culmination of one of a series of recurrent prophetic cycles, but rather
as marking the last and highest stage in the stupen-dous evolution of man's collective life on
this planet.

249 227-4

250 227-1. pdc, p. 3.

251 227-2. gwb, no. 4.1.227-3. gwb, no. 70.1.227-4. wob, p. 163.227 .4

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228 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

229 56it is in this context, we believe, that you will, through your own medita-

230 tions and your association with your fellow bahá'ís, find the answers to the

231 questions that concern you. essentially, the bahá'í community is "pioneer-

232 ing" a new approach to the organization of society and the individual per-

233 son's relationship to it, one that is based on a spiritual conception of reality. This effort follows two parallel tracks. on the one hand, we do all we can

234 as bahá'ís to acquaint those around us, including the organizations of soci-

235 ety, with the principles and concepts revealed by bahá'u'lláh, in the hope

236 that this guidance may be put to practical use in the life of humanity. on

237 the other, we are slowly building a global community which demonstrates,

238 beyond argument, that humanity, in all its diversity, can learn to live and

239 work as a single people in a global homeland.

we cannot take on our consciences the responsibility for the way in

240 which others respond. Nor can we afford to be diverted from our efforts by the accumulating evidences around us of the suffering and destruction that results from humanity's present course of action. merely to glance back over

241 the past several decades is to realize how steadily and irresistibly bahá'u'lláh's

242 vision of humanity's destiny is being reflected in the objective experience of our world. This process is steadily gathering momentum, and the challenge to each bahá'í, as an individual, is to become an instrument of this historic

243 process.

244 we are, as you say, only a minority. but this has always been the case at

245 any great turning-point in history. it is the revelation of god that makes

246 this minority a creative force in history and that brings to each of its active

247 members the deepest sense of fulfillment that human life affords.

248 the spiritual search reflected in your letter, and assures you that it will pray

249 ardently in the holy Shrines that bahá'u'lláh will surround you with his

250 confirmation and blessing.

251 with loving b ahá'í greetings,

for Department of tHe secretariat227 .6

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Elucidation on the Role of the

Universal House of Justice

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]